

Development of a Defect Estimation Method for CFRP Interstage Structures with Holes using Finite Element Analysis and Graph Neural Networks

Keisuke Nishioka¹ Yuta Kojima² Toshiya Saito³ Masahito Washiya³ Kosuke Kawakami³ Mayu Muramatsu⁴

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¹Keio University, Sci. for Open & Environ. Systems ²Nagoya University

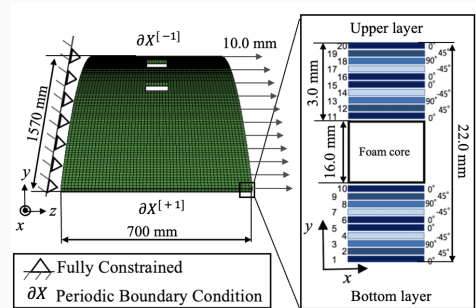
³JAXA, R&D Directorate ⁴Keio University, Mech. Engineering

Introduction: CFRP in space transportation

CFRP carries primary load in reusable launch vehicles (high specific strength) [1, 2].

Interlaminar delamination around bolt holes critically degrades integrity, especially under repeated use. Reliable *defect localization* is essential.

Conventional NDT — ultrasonic [3], X-ray CT [4], tap testing [5] — is costly and operator-dependent [6].



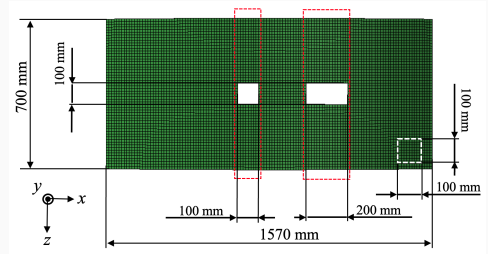
Perforated CFRP interstage panel (FEM).

Infrared stress measurement (DSPSS)

Thermoelastic effect relates a small temperature change to the change in the sum of principal stresses:

$$\Delta T = -k T \Delta \sigma_{\text{sum}}, \quad \sigma_{\text{sum}} = \sigma_1 + \sigma_2 + \sigma_3 = \text{tr}(\boldsymbol{\sigma}).$$

Infrared stress measurement [7-9] thus yields a **full-field surface map** of σ_{sum} (DSPSS), from which sub-surface defects are inferred.



DSPSS shows a stress valley over the defect.

Previous study and purpose

- **Previous study** [10, 11]: transfer learning with a CNN estimates defect position/size — but is tied to image grids and struggles on irregular, perforated geometry.
- **This work:** a **Graph Neural Network** (GAT) that consumes FEM-generated DSPSS to predict the *3-D defect location* (in-plane region $\times$ insertion layer) in perforated CFRP interstage structures.

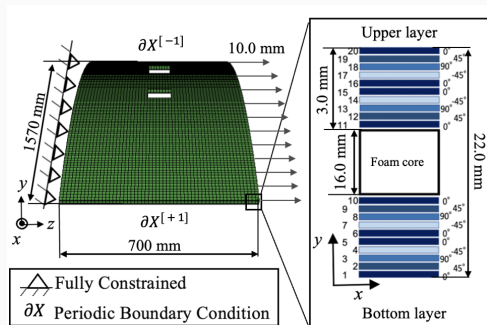
Why a graph?

The FEM surface mesh is naturally a graph; a GNN handles the irregular, hole-perforated topology that a CNN grid cannot.

FEM analysis conditions

- 1/80-scale curved panel ($R \approx 2$ m, $L \approx 1.57$ m, $t = 22$ mm).
- Holes of 100×100 and 200×100 mm.
- Sandwich laminate; tensile loading.
- Interlaminar delamination modeled explicitly by **Teflon inserts** between selected plies.

Synthetic dataset $\Rightarrow$ DSPSS fields with known ground-truth defects.



FEM boundary conditions & hole geometry.

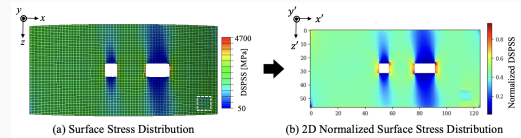
Input data: normalized / difference DSPSS

Raw DSPSS is dominated by **stress concentration around the hole**, masking the defect signal.

Remedy (paper):

- **Difference** field: damaged – defect-free reference;
- **Z-score normalization** (per node), improving depth-direction discrimination.

⇒ robust localization even near the opening.



Normalized DSPSS isolates the defect.

Stress distribution around the defect

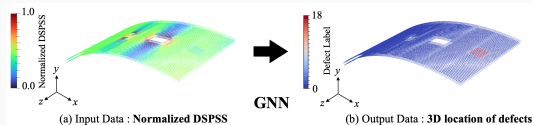
- DSPSS exhibits a clear **stress valley** at the defect centre.
- Depth and width of the valley depend on **ply angle**: 90° plies give sharp narrow valleys; $0^\circ/45^\circ$ broaden them.
- This ply-angle signature is what the network must learn to separate *which layer* the delamination sits in.

Implication

Layer discrimination is a *fine spatial-frequency* problem — motivating attention over local neighbourhoods.

Graph representation & GAT model

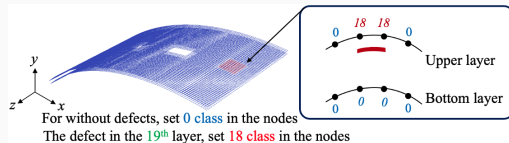
- **Nodes** = FEM surface elements; features = $(x, y, z, \hat{\sigma}_{\text{sum}})$.
- **Edges** = fixed mesh connectivity (reused across graphs).
- **GAT** [12, 13]: attention weights learn neighbour importance; message passing [14] over the mesh.
- Architecture: $3 \times \text{GATConv}$ (64 $\rightarrow$ 256 $\rightarrow$ 256), multi-head, batch-norm + dropout + residual connections.



Graph model on the perforated mesh.

Output: 3-D defect location as 19-class node labels

- Node classification into **19 classes**: class 0 = defect-free; remaining classes encode *in-plane region* $\times$ *insertion layer*.
- One-side labelling so prediction needs only single-surface DSPSS.



19-class label map.

Severe imbalance

Defect nodes are < 3% of all nodes — handled by the loss (next slide).

$$\text{FL}(p_t) = -\alpha_t (1 - p_t)^\gamma \log p_t.$$

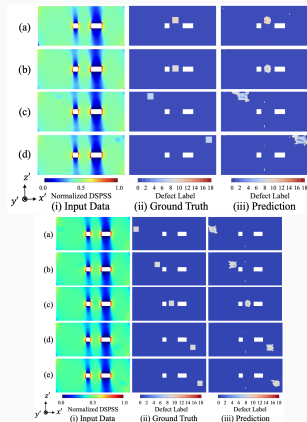
- Down-weights easy, abundant defect-free nodes; emphasises rare defect-class nodes [\[15\]](#).
- Crucial because intact regions dominate (> 97%).

Node features normalized; a single fixed edge list reused across all graphs.

Results: prediction accuracy

Test-set metrics:

- planar $R = 0.72$ (mean), depth $P_{\text{gauss}} = 0.69$, combined TDPS = 0.70 (best 0.92).
- Best layers: 9–12 (mid-thickness); Layer-10 samples all TDPS ≥ 0.82 .
- False-negative rate for defect nodes $< 3\%$.



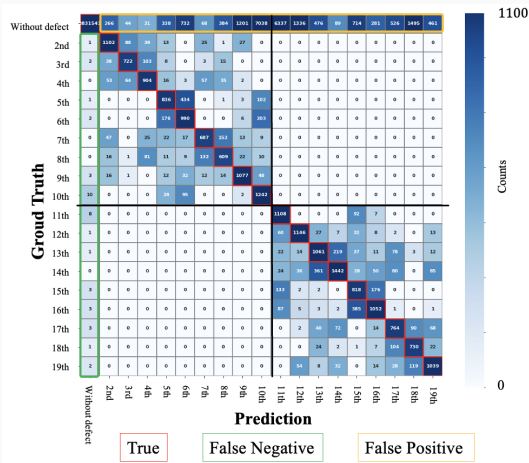
Predicted vs. true defect regions.

Overall performance & confusion

Headline

Macro-F1 = 61% across 19 classes, using *surface DSPSS only*.

- Dominant diagonal; residual *adjacent-layer* confusion.
- False positives cluster near the hole edge.
- Robust across defect insertion regions.



Confusion matrix (macro-F1 61%).

- Introduced an **FEM + GAT** framework for 3-D delamination localization in perforated CFRP interstage panels.
- **Difference-normalized DSPSS** suppresses hole stress concentration and enables full-region estimation.
- Achieved **macro-F1 61%** on 19 classes from surface data only, with a very low defect false-negative rate and no false detections in defect-free regions.

A scalable foundation

toward experimental infrared-stress (TSA) data and practical SHM of aerospace composite structures.

- **Noise robustness:** training with simulated acquisition noise (line + white noise) toward sim-to-real transfer.
- **Architecture study (preliminary):** extending from attention GNNs to *mesh-physics* GNNs (MeshGraphNet) and layered variants; early results are encouraging and under evaluation with co-authors.
- **Application:** transfer to aerospace payload-fairing SHM.

Preliminary; not part of the published results.

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